The Night Trails

The trails are walked, and the village holds its breath



Kijani at night - the temple in the middle, the fire shielded in the clearing, and the trails going out into the dark.

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar. This morning she freed a deer from a human's wire snare, half a morning's walk from the hidden village. Tonight there is no more practice. Oya has ordered every trail around Kijani walked quietly, in the dark - and Yara and Zola have been given the east trail. The one with the snares on it.

By BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.

CHAPTER 4

Nobody talked about the wire at the fire, because Oya had said nobody would, and so the evening did the strangest thing it could have done: it stayed ordinary.

The pot was low, as everyone now knew without being told, and the roots were stretched with leaves and the last of the dried fish, and Amara - who could make a meal out of weather, Zola said - had seasoned it into something that almost pretended to be enough. Children complained about being washed, exactly as that morning. The old woman who tended the fire spoke to it under her breath. A shelter rope was retied. A story was started, argued about, and started again.

Yara sat with her bowl held in both hands and understood, slowly, that the ordinariness was not an accident. At first it confused her, and then it made her angry - how could they eat, and laugh, with wire in the jungle? - and then the anger gave way to understanding. It was work. It was her mother, doing the other half of leading - the half that did not carry a spear.

All through the meal Oya moved around the clearing the way she always moved, and Yara, who could read people, watched her do it on purpose this time. She stopped longest where the fear would be. She ate with the family whose shelter wall Yara had helped to raise, and praised the wall. She asked the night watch - already fed, already armed - a plain question about the river level, as if the river were the only thing in the world that might rise tonight. Her fingers lingered a second too long as she retied a knot that did not need retieing, and once, when she thought no one was watching, her jaw tightened and she looked down at her own hands and breathed out slowly, as if setting something heavy down inside herself. Worry lived under her calm, and guilt under the worry - every order that might keep Kijani safe also sent someone she loved out into the dark. Then the calm settled over it again. She never once looked towards the east trail.

Only once did the evening nearly crack. The smallest child of the shelter family, the one who carried single leaves with tremendous ceremony, pointed into the dark beyond the firelight and asked, in the carrying voice of small children everywhere, whether that was where the bad wire lived.

Her mother hushed her. The clearing went very slightly quiet, the way a pond goes quiet under one finger.

Oya did not raise her voice. Her hand stayed flat and steady on the child's mother's shoulder, her markings low and even. "The wire is gone," Oya said, calmly, from where she stood. "Jabari brought it home and I have it safe. A thing that is found is a thing that can be watched for." She said it the way she said the river question, as if it were weather. Then she crouched a little, nearer the child's height, and her tone softened at the edges. "Finish your bowl. Wire does not eat children who finish their bowls."

The child considered this, found it sound, and finished her bowl. Somebody laughed - kindly, and with relief in it - and the story by the fire found its place again.

Yara looked down at her own empty bowl, her throat tight, so that no one would see her face doing what it was doing. That, she thought, is a queen. Not the temple steps. That.

The work began when the fire was allowed to fall, and it began without a speech.

Oya simply stood, and the hunters stood with her, the way water finds its level. On the temple steps, in the low red light of the coals, she gave the night out in pieces, the way she gave out everything: fairly, and with no piece repeated twice.

The river trail to two of the older hunters - walk it, close it, come home. The north slope to two builders who hunted better than they built - the same. The west trail, the old one towards the human paths, unused in a season, to Jabari. Alone. He received that the way he received weather, and Yara understood: it was his because it was the one a man might argue about, and nobody argued with Jabari in the dark.

Oya let her gaze travel once round the steps before it settled, and the coals ticked in the pause. "And the east trail," Oya said, "to Zola. And Yara."

There was a small silence, which Yara felt in her teeth. Fear dropped through her stomach first - cold, sudden - and under it, slower and steadier, came something she had not expected: hope, and pride, because her mother had said her name for real work in front of everyone. Her palms were damp where they pressed against her bowl. The east trail was not a lesson trail. It was the trail of the morning. It was the trail where the sentence in wire had been written, by a hand that intended to come back and read it.

Zola's eyebrows went up; her grin started, then faltered as she took in Oya's face. "Both of us?" Zola said, because Zola could ask the question that was hanging in the air and somehow make it sound like good manners.

"You read the ground," Oya said, level, one hand open towards Zola, then towards Yara. "She reads the one who walked on it. That is what Jabari tells me, and for once we are in agreement before midnight." Her eyes found Yara's across the coals. "Hear the orders, both of you, because they are the whole of the work. You walk it. You close it behind you. You count what has changed and you touch nothing you do not have to. If the line has been read since morning, you do not follow where it leads. If anything out there is wrong, you come home and say it first. Word before meat. Word before pride. Word before everything. Is that understood?"

"Yes," they said together - Yara with her chin up and her hands pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still, Zola suddenly straight-backed beside her, stepping half a pace closer until their shoulders almost touched - Zola's way, without words, of saying she would be there wherever Yara was sent.

"This is not the training ground," Oya said, and her markings dimmed with the weight of it. "There is no one out there to say *dead* and let you begin again." Then she stepped closer, and more quietly, so that it was for Yara and not for the steps, her hand hovering a breath from Yara's arm without quite touching: "That is why it is yours."

Amara was waiting at the edge of the clearing with a small pot of paste and no conversation at all. She took Yara's shoulder, worked the paste in with her thumbs, and said, her voice low and unhurried, feeling the knot in the muscle ease under her thumbs, "Breathe the way I taught you. Not the way fear teaches you." To Zola she said, with a look that pinned Zola where she stood, "And you. Bring her home at the speed of the slowest true thing, not the fastest brave one."

Zola clutched her chest as if struck, though her eyes were laughing. "Healer," Zola said, wounded, "I am famous for my restraint."

"You are famous," Amara said, dry as dust, not looking up, "for volume." She pressed two fingers once to Yara's wrist, where the pulse was, as if she were memorising it for later comparison. "Go on, then. The dark is not getting younger."

The jungle at night was not a darker version of the jungle by day. It was a different country that happened to use the same trees.

Yara had known that all her life, the way you know a song. Knowing it and being given a share of it to guard were not the same thing. Out beyond the tree line, with Kijani's fire gone behind the leaves and the canopy shut over them like a hand, her senses opened the way they were meant to open - not in a flare, not in a flood, but steadily, the way Amara had promised they would if she stopped gripping them.

Out, long, through the nose. Put down the feeling that feeds it.

The river first, always, the great low note under everything. Insects in layers, stitching the dark together. A night bird, offended, far to the left. Water over stone. The breathing of the girl beside her, who moved - even Zola, *especially* Zola - in a quiet so complete it had texture, like cloth.

Their markings stayed down. That was the first discipline of the night walk, and it was not for hiding from prey. It was for hiding from eyes. Out here, a glow was a door left open, and Yara's mother did not leave doors open, and so neither, tonight, would Yara. When excitement rose in her - at a scent, at a sound she could not name fast enough - she felt the shimmer climb her arms like water climbing a bank, and she breathed, and let it sink, and was absurdly proud the third time it sank without her having to think about sinking it.

Zola's shoulder brushed hers, warm in the dark, and her whisper came with a grin in it. "You are doing the healer's face," Zola whispered.

Yara kept her eyes forward, annoyed that it was true, her markings flickering once before she breathed them down again. "I am doing the healer's breathing."

"It comes with a face. I am just telling you, in case queens are not allowed that face." A pause, in which Zola read a whole paragraph of ground by the soles of her feet, then nudged Yara very gently with an elbow, fond and teasing at once. "It is working, though. You are almost not a lantern."

They worked the trail the way the morning's line had worked, except that now there was no lesson in it, and that changed every step. Zola went first, a few paces ahead, spear carried low across her body, head turning slowly from ground to trees and back. Yara walked behind her, close enough to see Zola's hand when it rose, far enough back that one trap, or one fall, could not take them both. Yara kept one hand slightly raised, ready to signal, and the other loose at her side, feeling the night air move over her skin for any change. Hand signs did the talking. Stop. Scent. Listen. Down. Twice they froze for animals that were only animals - once a heavy, rootling shape that grunted and moved off, and Yara thought of the sow, somewhere out in the green dark with her three striped shadows pressed close, and hoped, with her whole dimmed heart, that the night stayed boring for her too.

Behind them, every few hundred paces, they closed the trail. A pressed leaf pressed back. A branch drawn across soft earth. A footprint - never theirs for long - scuffed out with the side of a foot and leaf mould. Yara had done this work that morning understanding it from the other side. Tonight she understood it from underneath: it was not tidying. It was the village, erasing its own name from the ground, over and over, so that no stranger could ever read it aloud.

Halfway to the gully, Zola stopped without a sign, which was itself a sign, and the worst kind.

Yara went still beside her and waited, because one of the things the day had taught her was that Zola's silences were information too.

Zola's hand came up, fingers spread - stop - and her nose lifted, her whole body gone alert. "Smell that," Zola breathed.

Yara let the dark come in through her nose in layers, the way Amara sorted herbs: river, rot, wet leaf, animal, the clean green smell of a vine cut hours ago and already healing. And under it - faint, wrong, and instantly familiar, because she had held it in her hands that morning and it had not left her since - metal. Not much. Not near. A rumour of metal, carried on the wet air, from up the trail.

Yara's throat closed round the memory of it in her hands. "Wire," she said, barely aloud.

"Or the place where wire was." Zola's head turned slowly, reading, her voice kept low and flat so it would not carry. "Ground says nothing new has walked our trail. Whatever that is, it is off it, or above it, or old." She looked at Yara sideways. "So. Read him, then. That is your side of the work. Who is he, princess, this man of ours?"

Yara almost snapped that he was not *theirs*. Then she understood the question properly, and it steadied her, the way Jabari's cruelty on the training ground had steadied her - by giving her fear a shape to stand next to.

"He is patient," she said, slowly, her breath evening out as the shape of him came clear in her mind, thinking of the bent sapling, the chosen place above water. "He does not hunt the way we hunt. He sets a thing and leaves it to be hungry for him. He trusts his tools more than his feet." Cold anger rose in her as she spoke - anger at a man who could sit still and let hunger do his hunting for him - and her markings prickled with it until she breathed it down. Her fingers tightened, then loosened, as she thought of the vine, cut through in one clean stroke to clear the line. "He keeps his line tidy. Like a path he owns. He thinks this part of the jungle is his, because he has marked it and no one has argued." She stopped. "And he comes back. A man who only wanted the setting would not need the line kept. He comes back to read what it caught."

Zola was quiet a moment, studying her in the dark, the teasing gone out of her face. "That is a frightening amount to get from two wires and a smell."

Yara lifted one shoulder, a tight little shrug, and let out a breath she had been holding. "It is what Jabari said. Think like the one who laid it."

"Hm." Zola started forward again, slower now, placing each foot like a word she could take back. "Remind me never to lay a trail in front of you. I would come home and find you knowing my grandmother's secrets and what I had for breakfast." She shook her head as she said it, half admiring, half unsettled.

"Roots," Yara said, and felt a small, tired smile pull at her mouth in the dark. "Same as me. It was not a hard trail."

Zola's grin flashed in the dark, brief as a firefly, and was put away again - because they were coming, now, down the shallow slope Yara remembered in her knees before she remembered it in her mind, to the gully where a young deer had stood that morning spending the last of itself on being stone.

The gully was empty, and the empty was wrong in a way that took Yara a moment to untangle - until she realised she had been expecting the sapling.

It was still there, of course. Trees did not leave. But the strain had gone out of it. Jabari had held it down that morning while the wire hung slack, and afterwards it had sprung back only part of the way, still bent a little towards the ground, like a bow half-drawn. Now it stood straighter. Taller than she remembered. As if something had eased it the rest of the way home - recently, and by hand.

Zola was already crouched at its foot, not touching, reading with her eyes the way other people read with fingers.

Zola's fingertips hovered over the bark, not touching, and her voice dropped until it was almost part of the dark. "He has been here," she said, very quietly. "Since us. Since morning."

They found the rest of it the way you find a sentence, word by word, in an order that only frightened them once it was whole.

First, the watching place: on the far bank, a fan of ferns had been pressed flat - not broken, not cut, *pressed*, over hours, by someone sitting very still in the one place where the gully, the game trail, and the water could all be watched at once without being seen. Yara lowered herself, carefully, into the shape of it, and felt the jungle arrange itself in front of her exactly as it must have for him. The snare had hung there. The water shone there. Anything thirsty would cross that ground.

Yara's hand rose to her mouth; her markings gave one sick flare and she forced them down. "He sat here while the deer was - " She could not finish it.

Zola reached towards her, stopped herself - orders - and let the gentleness do the work instead. "No," Zola said, from the earth, and there was something almost gentle in it. "Look. The pressing is old under the new. He sat here many times before the deer. This is not a place a man finds once, princess. This is a place a man *keeps*."

Second, the line itself. They walked it the way Oya had ordered: counting, touching nothing. Where the first snare had hung there was bare sapling and a bright new scar in the bark - the mark of wire taken off in a hurry by the man who had put it there, and found his trap gone and another man's work in its place. Where the second snare had hung, the same. He had read his line, exactly as Yara had said he would. He had found it emptied. He had taken what was left of it away with him.

And third - fifty paces further on than they had walked that morning, past the place where the hunt had ended and the word had gone home - a third snare, sprung.

Yara crouched beside Zola without touching it, knees in the damp mould, leaning in until she could see the feathers clearly. It hung open and empty at ankle height, its loop sprung shut on nothing but air and a scatter of grey-brown feathers, very small, pressed into the leaf mould underneath. A small, stubborn hope moved in her chest as she looked at them: whatever had been caught here had not stayed caught. Whatever it had caught had not been there when he came to read his line. Something - a bird, a small quick thing of the ground - had got out of it, or been got out of it, before he arrived. Or had been taken out of it by something else entirely, and carried away into a jungle that did not explain itself.

Zola's hand shot up, sharp, real fear under the order in her eyes. "Do not," Zola said, before Yara had even moved. "Orders. Touch nothing we do not have to. It counts as changed, princess. That is enough. It gets to be a number in your report, not a thing in your hands."

It was on the way back up out of the gully that the night offered Yara the thing she would have to refuse.

A sign. Not on their trail - across it. A line of bent grass and disturbed mould, coming down off the far bank from the watching place and heading away, east and north, into the deep green where no village trail ran at all. It was not old, like the pressing of the ferns. It was not hours old, like the eased sapling. Down in the damp hollow where the air sat still, Zola crouched over it for a long time, and when she stood up her face had lost every trace of the girl who made jokes about breakfast.

Her jaw was tight, her markings flaring once before she forced them down. "That is tonight," she said. "That may be *this hour*. He read his line, he found it robbed, and he went that way. Looking." A beat. "Or leaving. I cannot swear which, and I will not lie to you on a night trail, princess. The ground there will tell us. Fifty paces would tell us."

Fifty paces.

Yara stood with the dark pressing in and felt the pull of it go through her like a hook finding cloth. Fifty paces to know whether a man was walking *towards* her village in the dark, this hour, while her mother sat trusting that the word would come home first. Fifty paces was nothing. Zola would go - she could feel Zola waiting for the word, ready to go, ready in fact to be told *not* to go, because Zola was standing in the dark asking with her whole body for Yara to be the one who decided.

Word before pride. Her mother's voice, on the temple steps, in the low red light. *There is no one out there to say dead and let you begin again.*

In her mind she saw her mother in the hut doorway, waiting. She saw the village behind its closed trail, children asleep in the shelters, trusting that the dark would be watched for them. Fear said follow him, before he found them. Pride said follow him, and come home with the answer. Both voices were hers, and she heard them clearly, and that was how she knew not to obey either one. And underneath that, older and quieter, Jabari on the training ground: *Anger is loud, princess.* This was not anger. But it shone the same way. It wanted the same thing - to move now, and be right later.

Yara's hands fisted at her sides; her markings flared, bright and wanting, and sank as she breathed through it. "No," Yara said. It came out rough, because it cost. "We were not sent to meet him. We were sent to know. And we know." She made herself say the rest of it properly, like a report, because a report was a thing she could hold. "He came back. He read his line. He found it emptied. He may still be looking. That is the word, and the word goes home first, whole, and fast. If we follow him and he finds us instead, then the word never gets home at all, and Kijani learns about him from his mouth, not ours."

Zola let out a breath she had clearly been saving, and a shaky ghost of her grin came back. "I hate it when the orders are right," she said. "It is so much worse than when they are stupid."

Yara nodded once, towards the trail, her own breathing steadying as the decision settled. "Mark it," Yara said. "Our way. Where only we will read it."

So Zola went down on one knee at the edge of the trail and made, in thirty seconds and with two fingers and a broken twig laid just *so*, the smallest sign Yara had ever seen her make: a Vey'kar trail mark, old as the temple, that said to any hunter of Kijani who ever passed this way again - *here. This far. No further, on this night, without the word.* To anyone else alive it was leaf mould and a fallen twig, and it would be gone by rain.

Then they went home the way a word should go home: without stopping, without shining, and with the trail closing behind them like water.

Oya took their report standing, in the dark of her own hut doorway, with the coils of dead wire on the floor between them like a second, smaller fire.

Yara gave it as she had rehearsed it on the walk home, in order, with the numbers in it. Two snares taken up by their owner. A watching place kept, not found, above the gully. A third snare further on, sprung and empty, small feathers under it. A fresh sign leading away east and north. Not followed. Marked.

Oya went very still; her eyes searched Yara's face, looking for the wanting underneath the words. "Not followed," Oya repeated, quiet.

Yara stood straight under that gaze, keeping her hands deliberately unclenched at her sides. "The orders were word first," Yara said. "It may have been him leaving. It may have been him looking. Fifty paces would have told us, and we did not spend them."

Her mother's face, in the low light, did one of its complicated things and was still. For a heartbeat, though, Yara saw through it: relief first, flooding in, then pride, and underneath both the same guilt she had glimpsed at the fire - because Oya had sent her own daughter into that dark, and had sat and waited, and could not have done otherwise. Oya gathered it all away, the way she gathered everything, and was the queen again.

Oya turned slowly to Zola, one eyebrow rising, disbelief and something warmer underneath it. "Zola," Oya said. "You let her refuse you a trail. In the dark. Willingly."

Zola's hands hung loose and tired at her sides; she met the queen's eyes without flinching. "She refused herself first, my queen," Zola said, and there was not a joke anywhere in her. "I only had to stand there and watch it cost her. It is a very educational sight."

Jabari had come in without anyone hearing him, the way weather arrives, and stood at the edge of the doorway light with his spear in his hand. He had walked the west trail alone and come home with nothing to report, and that made him the most dangerous listener in the hut.

His grip shifted on the spear, a small, approving sound buried in his throat. "She left a mark," he said.

Zola lifted her chin, defensive on Yara's behalf, though her voice stayed respectful. "Our mark, Elder," Zola said. "Small as a lie. Rain takes it."

"And she closed the trail behind her, all the way home, at speed, in the dark." He was not asking Zola. His arms were folded, his chin down, his whole stance one long disapproval - but it was a testing kind of disapproval now, the kind that watched to be proved wrong. He was, Yara realised, reading her - the mud to the knee, the cloak still settled right on her shoulders, the markings, even now, held low and steady. "Twice in one day the girl has come home empty-handed," he said to Oya, "and twice she has brought back the thing the village actually needed. I begin to see a pattern in it, and I do not care for patterns." He turned to go. He stopped, because stopping at doorways to deliver one last sentence was, Yara suspected, the whole reason Jabari had doorways. "East trail. Tomorrow night. She leads it. A leader who will not be led by her own wanting is - " He searched, visibly, for a colder word, and failed to find one he would spend. " - less of a danger than I reported at dawn."

And he was gone, into a dark he needed no eyes for.

Oya looked at her daughter for a long moment.

Oya laid a hand on Yara's shoulder then, and left it there, its weight warm and steady. "You lead it," she said. "Zola walks with you - as your tracker, Yara, not your keeper. That is different, and you will both feel the difference by midnight tomorrow." She bent, picked up one coil of wire, held it a moment, then set it back down gently, as if it were asleep. "Sleep now. Both of you. A village that is being looked for does not get to be tired in the morning."

Yara slept the way a held breath rests: lightly, and all in one piece, and she woke before dawn with Zola's voice already in the doorway of the hut, arguing happily with somebody about whose turn it was to be slow.

The village woke around her - no. She had learned this on her first morning, and she said it right this time, even in her head. Kijani did not wake. It continued. The night watch came down from the trees and handed the dark over to the louder people, and among the people coming down, walking the last of the river trail with the empty, ordinary hands of a hunter who had found nothing and closed everything, were hunters who nodded to her as they passed.

Not the nod you give a princess on temple steps while her mother is talking. A shorter one. A working one. The nod you give someone who was out in the same dark you were out in, doing a share of the same work.

She carried that nod down to Amara's hut to have her shoulder seen to, and Amara took one look at her face, hands on her hips, her sharp eyes softening with the quiet knowing of a woman who had already read the whole night in Yara's pulse and her held-low markings, and then at her wrist, where the pulse was, and said, "Same girl who left. Slightly more of her. Sit. Eat. You will tell me all of it while I pretend not to be listening, which is the healer's custom, and then you will tell me the parts you left out of the report."

Yara looked away, both hands tightening at her sides, her markings dimming in a way that gave her away. "There were no parts left out of the report."

"There is always a part left out of a report, child. It is the part where you were frightened." Amara set a bowl in her hands. "That part is mine. Eat first. Fear keeps." She said it gently, and let her hand linger a moment on Yara's as she passed the bowl, warm and matter-of-fact.

Later - much later, when the light was full and the clearing sounded, blessedly, like nothing more alarming than a village building itself - Yara stood at the edge of the training ground and let the morning be ordinary on purpose, the way her mother had let the evening be ordinary, and understood she had been handed a second inheritance. Not the crown. Not yet. The *calm*. The work of keeping twenty frightened people fed and building and laughing, while somewhere out in the green a patient man sat in a place he kept, read his emptied line, and wondered what kind of thing walked his jungle at night, took his traps apart without breaking them, freed what they caught, and left no trail home.

And she would be out there when he did - not only the girl who had been tested at dawn, but someone the village now nodded to in the working way. That thought steadied her, and frightened her, in equal measure. He would come back. That was the truest thing she knew about him, truer than his patience, truer than his tidy line. A man does not abandon a question he has paid that much sitting-still for. He had lost two snares and found a mystery, and a mystery, to a man like that, was worth more than a deer.

He would come back to read his line again.

And next time, Yara thought - not with fear, exactly, and not without it either - next time the line would not be all he was reading for.

End of Chapter 4

Yara walked the night trails as real work, not practice - and came home having chosen the word over the chase. Jabari, in his own way, has said she should lead the east trail herself. But the man who set the snares has now read his emptied line, and he knows something in his jungle is taking it apart.

Next: Chapter 5 - Yara leads the east trail for the first time, the village settles into a new watch, and the question of what Oya keeps of Ayo's presses closer - as Act 1 draws towards its close.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages - Act 1 is Chapters 1-5, Act 2 is Chapters 6-14, Act 3 is Chapters 15-20. Chapters 1-4 are now written. Series: The Yara Chronicles. Book 1: Daughter of Two Worlds.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.